

UNIT ONE

Foundations of Communication



In the words of educational philosopher, Robert M. Hutchins, former dean of the Yale Law School and former president and chancellor of the University of Chicago,

A world community can only exist with world communication, which means something more than extensive software facilities scattered about the globe. It means common understanding, a common tradition, common ideas and common ideals.

The title of the book you are about to read is *Communicate!* and from it you will gain skills designed to help you achieve what Hutchins describes. Before we embark on our journey, however, we ought to begin with a common understanding of what *communication* means. We know that communication has to do with things like reading, writing, talking, and listening. What people sometimes fail to realize, however, is that communication is something we can learn to do more effectively through study and practice.

At its core, communication stems from the desire to share our thoughts, feelings, and ideas with others. We do this through the messages we send and receive every day. Messages are made up of a combination of verbal symbols (words), nonverbal cues (behaviors), and perhaps visual images. Through reflection and analysis, we interpret the messages of others—sometimes accurately and sometimes not.

New technologies provide new channels for communicating and new challenges. For example, e-mailing, texting, tweeting, blogging, Facebook messaging, Skypeing, and Snapchatting are expanding our ability to stay in touch with distant others. With these opportunities, however, comes an intensified need to improve our communication competence as we tailor our messages to be appropriate for these different communication channels. So this book focuses on effective communication (1) in various settings such as interpersonal encounters, small groups, and public forums, as well as (2) using a variety of channels ranging from flat print to face-to-face to mediated and technology-driven ones.

This first unit consists of six chapters devoted to the fundamental elements of effective communication. In Chapter 1, we discuss the nature of communication and the communication process. Chapter 2 focuses on perceptions of self and perceptions of others. Chapter 3 examines how cultural norms affect communication. Chapter 4 is devoted to verbal messages and Chapter 5 to nonverbal messages. Finally, Chapter 6 examines the listening process and offers specific suggestions for improving listening skills when communicating in both face-to-face and virtual settings. By the time you finish this introductory unit, you will be ready—and we hope excited—to study how to apply these basic concepts in interpersonal, group, and public communication contexts.

Foundations of Communication

When you've finished this chapter, you will be able to:

- Describe the nature of communication.
- Define key components in the communication process.
- Explain the characteristics of communication.
- Assess messages using the principles of ethical communication.
- Develop a personal communication improvement plan.

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Start with a quick warm-up activity.

Jennifer was running late. She stood at the kitchen counter eating a piece of toast while preparing a grocery list she would use on her way home from work. She noticed that the Weather Channel was forecasting heavy rain and wondered where she left her umbrella. She added “get umbrella” to her shopping list. Jennifer quickly texted Greta, a coworker she was driving with to work today, to ask if Greta had an extra one she could borrow.

As she was texting Greta, Jennifer’s 16-year-old daughter, Hailey, bounded into the kitchen and asked, “Mom, can I get a tattoo? Kayla and Whitney are both getting them and we want to match.”

“Not now, Hailey. I’m late for work. We can talk about it tonight.”

“But mom. . . .”

“Yes, Hailey, yes, alright. We’ll talk more tonight. . . .” Jennifer exclaimed as she headed to the door. Just then she heard her computer signal an incoming e-mail message. Jennifer thought, “I’d better just get going. I can check it on my phone on the way to pick up Greta.”

As Hailey waited for the school bus, she quickly texted her friends, “Awesome! My mom said YES!”



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Read, highlight, and take notes online.

APPLY IT

Consider a time when someone started reading or sending texts on their smart phone while you were talking to them. How did that influence your opinion of them? Of their interest in you? Of the value they place on your relationship?

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Can you relate to Jennifer? We live in an era when multitasking has become a norm. Part of that multitasking includes communicating both with ourselves and with others. Like Jennifer, we get ready for work or school while checking voice messages and Facebook pages, answering texts and e-mails, as well as eating breakfast, monitoring the forecast, and getting dressed.

Some argue that the same technology that was supposed to simplify life has actually made it more complex. In fact, communication today extends across interpersonal, group, and public communication settings through flat print, face-to-face, and mediated technology-enhanced channels. Jennifer, for example, composed her grocery list on *a piece of paper* while learning about the weather forecast on *television* and texting Greta on her *smart phone*. Then, when Hailey tried to talk to her *face to face*, Jennifer was so distracted that her communication signals implied to Hailey that she had granted Hailey permission to get a tattoo.

Unfortunately, one of the negative consequences of having so many modes through which we can communicate is the false sense of competence it gives us about our ability to have several conversations at once. This chapter and the ones that follow focus on *why* it's important to improve our communication skills and *how* to do so. As a result, we can avoid the negative consequences of ineffective communication that can hurt our personal and professional relationships.

At its core, communication is the attempt to satisfy the innate human desire to share our thoughts, feelings, and ideas with others. We do this through the messages we send and receive every day. Messages are made up of a combination of verbal symbols (words), nonverbal cues (behaviors), and visual images.

New technologies provide new channels and new challenges for communicating. For example, e-mailing, texting, tweeting, blogging, Skypeing, and Facebooking are expanding our ability to communicate with distant others around the world. With these opportunities, however, comes an intensified need to tailor our messages for the different channels we use and the different audiences those channels might address.

What this book intends to help you learn, then, is how to communicate effectively (1) in various settings such as interpersonal encounters, small groups, and public forums, as well as (2) using a variety of channels ranging from flat print to face-to-face to technology-driven ones.

Our ability to make and keep friends, to be good members of our families, to have satisfying intimate relationships, to participate in or lead groups, and to prepare and present formal speeches and presentations depends on our communication skills. Time

and time again, surveys and studies conclude that employers of college graduates seek oral communication, teamwork, and interpersonal skills (College Learning for the New Global Century, 2008; Darling & Dannels, 2003; Hansen & Hansen, 2007; Hart, 2006; Young, 2003). Unfortunately, these same employers also say communication skills are the ones many new graduates lack (Hart, 2010). Thus, what you learn from this book can not only improve your personal relationships, but also increase your ability to get a job and be successful in your chosen career (Photo 1.1).

Photo 1.1 What are your career goals? How might effective communication help you achieve them?



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We begin this chapter by describing the nature of communication and the communication process followed by several characteristics of communication and ethical considerations. Finally, we explain how to become a more competent communicator by developing and following your own personal communication improvement plan.

The Nature of Communication

Communication is a complex process through which we express, interpret, and coordinate messages with others. We do so to create shared meaning, to meet social goals, to manage personal identity, and to carry out our relationships. At its core, then, communication is about messages.

Messages are the verbal utterances, visual images, and nonverbal behaviors used to convey thoughts and feelings. We refer to the process of creating messages as **encoding** and the process of interpreting them as **decoding**. So when a toddler points to her bottle and cries out “Ba-ba,” her message (comprised of a nonverbal gesture—pointing—and a verbal utterance—“Ba-ba”) expresses her desire for her caregiver to give her the bottle of milk. How the caregiver responds, however, depends on how he or she decodes the message. The caregiver might respond by handing her the bottle or by saying, “Sorry, cutie, the bottle is empty.” Either response is also a message. **Feedback** is a response message that indicates how the initial message was interpreted.

communication

the process through which we express, interpret, and coordinate messages with others

messages

the verbal utterances, visual images, and nonverbal behaviors used to convey thoughts and feelings

encoding

the process of putting our thoughts and feelings into words and nonverbal behaviors

decoding

the process of interpreting another’s message

feedback

responses to messages

canned plan

a “mental library” of scripts each of us draws from to create messages based on what worked in the past

script

an actual text of what to say and do in a specific situation

Canned Plans and Scripts

But how do we actually go about encoding (or forming) and decoding (or interpreting) messages? We begin based on our canned plans and scripts. A **canned plan** is a “mental library” of scripts each of us draws from to create messages based on what worked for us or others in the past (Berger, 1997). A **script** is an actual text of what to say and do in a specific situation. We have canned plans and scripts for a wide variety of interactions like greeting people, making small talk, giving advice, complimenting or criticizing someone, and persuading others. Each canned plan may contain many scripts tailored to different people and occasions. For example, we may have a “canned greeting plan” that contains a different script for greeting a friend, family member, co-worker, or supervisor. It may also include tailored scripts for doing so in person, over e-mail, or on social media. Patricia, for example, typically begins e-mail messages to her friends by greeting them with their first name. However, when she writes to her professors, she always begins with “Dear Professor.” Doing so helps convey respect for their authority.

Suppose you spot a good friend sitting at a table across the room from you at a restaurant. How might you say hello? How might you tailor your greeting if that person is a romantic partner, work supervisor, co-worker, or classmate?

We develop canned plans and scripts from our own previous experiences and by observing what appears to work or not work for other people, even fictitious people we see on TV or in movies (Frank, Prestin, Chen, & Nabi, 2009) (Photo 1.2). When our canned plan doesn’t appear to include a good script for a specific situation, we search for scripts that are *similar* to the current situation and customize an appropriate message. For example, if you have never met a celebrity, you probably don’t have a greeting script for doing so in your canned plan mental library. Suppose you are waiting to board a plane and spot a famous athlete, singer, or actor also waiting to board. What would you say?

APPLY IT

What do you say when you greet (a) a stranger you pass on the sidewalk, (b) a casual friend or classmate, (c) a romantic partner, or (d) a family member? In what ways are your scripts similar and different? Why?

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AP Images/Rob Bennett

Photo 1.2 Sometimes we develop canned plans and scripts by observing fictional characters or people on TV. What television programs might have influenced your canned plans and scripts? Why and how?

communication context
the physical, social, historical, psychological, and cultural situations that surround a communication event

physical situation
location, environmental conditions (temperature, lighting, noise level), distance between communicators, seating arrangements, and time of day

social presence
a sense of “being there” with another person virtually

social situation
the nature of the relationship that exists between participants

historical situation
the background provided by previous communication between the participants

As you figure that out, you are likely to draw from similar scripts and customize them for the person and occasion.

The point here is that we don’t usually start from scratch to form messages. Instead we recognize what type of message we want to form, search our mental canned plan library for an appropriate script, and then customize it to fit the unique parts of the current situation. All of this mental choosing typically happens in nanoseconds. We also use our canned plans and scripts to interpret messages from others. Obviously, the larger your canned plan library is, the more likely you will be to form appropriate and effective messages, as well as understand and respond appropriately to the messages of others.

Communication Context

According to noted German philosopher Jürgen Habermas, the ideal communication situation is impossible to achieve, but considering context as we communicate can move us closer to that goal (Littlejohn & Foss, 2010). The **communication context** is made up of the physical, social, historical, psychological, and cultural situations that surround a communication event.

The **physical situation** includes the location, the environmental conditions (temperature, lighting, noise level), and the physical proximity of participants to each other. The physical situation may also be virtual as we interact with others via social media on our computers, tablets, and smart phones. The physical situation can influence how we interpret the messages we send and receive. We are likely to be most successful when we are present with those with whom we are interacting, either literally, as in face-to-face situations, or virtually. The term we use for creating a sense of “being there” with another person virtually is **social presence**. One technology-enhanced communication channel that does not lend itself to conveying social presence is e-mail. As a result, e-mail messages can often be misinterpreted, cause hurt feelings, or damage relationships. Jonas, for instance, gasped when he read the e-mail from his professor that seemed to be accusing him of cheating. He began to fire off a reply but stopped and made an appointment to speak in person so as to avoid the misinterpretation that can come from the lack of social presence provided via e-mail.

The **social situation** is the nature of the relationship that already exists between the participants. The better you know someone and the better relationship you have with them, the more likely you are to accurately interpret their messages and to give them the benefit of the doubt when a message seems negative.

The **historical situation** is the background provided by previous communication between the participants. For instance, suppose Chas texts Anna to tell her he will pick up the draft of the report they had left for their manager. When Anna sees Chas at lunch later that day, she says, “Did you get it?” Another person listening to the conversation would have no idea what the “it” is to which Anna is referring. Yet Chas may well

reply, “It’s on my desk.” Anna and Chas understand one another because of their earlier exchange.

The **psychological situation** includes the moods and feelings each person brings to the encounter. For instance, suppose Corinne is under a great deal of stress. While studying for an exam, a friend stops by and asks her to take a break to go to the gym. Corinne, who is normally good-natured, may respond with an irritated tone of voice, which her friend may misinterpret as Corinne being mad at him.

psychological situation
the moods and feelings each person brings to a conversation

The **cultural situation** includes the beliefs, values, orientations, underlying assumptions, and rituals that belong to a specific culture (Samovar, Porter, & McDaniel, 2009). Everyone is part of one or more cultural group (e.g., race, ethnicity, religion, age, sex, gender, sexual orientation, physical ability). When two people from different cultures interact, misunderstandings may occur because of their different cultural values, beliefs, orientations, and rituals. The *Communicating in the World* section in this chapter describes how the cultural ritual of mourning is changing in the United States today.

cultural situation
the beliefs, values, orientations, underlying assumptions, and rituals that belong to a specific culture

COMMUNICATING IN THE WORLD

Mourning in the United States, 21st-Century Style



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Mourning is a universal human communication process of celebrating the life of someone while grieving his or her death. Mourning rituals and traditions vary by culture and religion and change over time. So it is not surprising that mourning in the United States in the 21st century is adapting past practices to modern life.

Today in the United States, for instance, many of the rituals traditionally associated with funerals and memorial services often take place online. Increasingly, one or more family member may prepare

a commemorative Web page that memorializes the life of the departed. For example, an article in the *Boston Globe* recounted the story of Shawn Kelley, who created a “moving tribute” to his brother Michael, a National Guardsman killed in Afghanistan. The 60-second video features a slide show of images of Michael growing up while quiet classical music plays softly and a voice-over recounts Michael’s attributes and interests. Shawn reported that it made him feel good to be able to “talk” about his brother, and over a year later he was still visiting the site to watch the video and to view the messages that continue to be left by family members and friends (Plumb, 2006). The popularity of such Web sites can be summarized in the fact that Legacy.com, the most popular site for posting online memorials, boasts of more than 24 million unique visitors each month (<http://www.legacy.com/ns/about/>).

How did you/do you mourn when someone you care about dies? How do you share messages with others in the process?

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Communication Settings

communication setting
the different communication environments within which people interact

intrapersonal communication
the interactions that occur in a person's mind when he or she is talking with himself or herself

interpersonal communication
informal interaction between two people who have an identifiable relationship with each other

small-group communication
three to 20 people who come together for the specific purpose of solving a problem or arriving at a decision

public communication
one participant, the speaker, delivers a message to a group of more than 20 people

The communication setting also affects how we form and interpret messages. **Communication settings** differ based on the number of participants and the level of formality in the interactions (Littlejohn & Foss, 2008, pp. 52–53). These settings are intrapersonal, interpersonal, small group, public, and mass.

Intrapersonal communication refers to the interactions that occur in our minds when we are talking to ourselves (Photo 1.3). We usually don't verbalize our intrapersonal communication. When you sit in class and think about what you'll do later that day or when you send yourself a reminder note as an e-mail or text message, you are communicating intrapersonally. A lot of our intrapersonal communication occurs subconsciously (Kellerman, 1992). When we drive into the driveway "without thinking," we are communicating intrapersonally on a subconscious level. The study of intrapersonal communication often focuses on its role in shaping self-perceptions and in managing communication apprehension, that is, the fear associated with communicating with others (Richmond & McCroskey, 1997). Our study of intrapersonal communication focuses on self-talk as a means to improve self-concept and self-esteem and, ultimately, communication competence in a variety of situations.

Interpersonal communication is characterized by informal interaction between two people who have an identifiable relationship with each other (Knapp & Daly, 2002). Talking to a friend between classes, visiting on the phone with your mother, and texting or chatting online with your brother are all examples of interpersonal communication. In Part II of this book, our study of interpersonal communication includes the exploration of how we develop, maintain, improve, and end interpersonal relationships.

Small-group communication typically involves three to 20 people who come together to communicate with one another (Beebe & Masterson, 2006; Hirokawa, Cathcart, Samovar, & Henman, 2003). Examples of small groups include a family, a group of friends, a group of classmates working on a project, and a workplace management team. Small-group communication can occur in face-to-face settings, as well as online through electronic mailing lists, discussion boards, virtual meetings, and blogs. In Part III, our study of small groups focuses on the characteristics of effective groups, ethical and effective communication in groups, leadership, problem-solving, conflict, and group presentations.

Public communication is delivered to audiences of more than 20 people. Examples include public speeches, presentations, and forums we may experience in person or via mediated or technology-driven channels. For example, when a president delivers the State of the Union address, some people may be in attendance on location, others watch on TV or the Internet, and still others view it later in the form of televised broadcast snippets, digital recordings, or Internet videos. The Internet is also becoming the medium of choice for posting job ads and résumés, for advertising and buying products, and for political activism. In Part IV, our study of public communication focuses on preparing, practicing, and delivering effective oral presentations in both face-to-face and virtual environments.

Photo 1.3 We communicate intrapersonally when we talk to ourselves, reflect about people and events, and write in a journal. What are some examples of your own intrapersonal communication activities today?



Amplify/istockphoto.com

Mass communication is delivered by individuals and entities through mass media to large segments of the population at the same time. Some examples include newspaper and magazine articles and advertisements, as well as radio and television programs and advertisements. The bonus chapter on mass communication and media literacy focuses specifically on effective mass communication in both flat print and digital modalities.

mass communication
communication delivered through mass media to large segments of the population at the same time

APPLY IT

How much of your communication each day is intrapersonal versus interpersonal, versus public versus mass communication? What are some examples of each you've engaged in so far today?

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The Communication Process

The **communication process** is a complex set of three different and interrelated activities intended to result in shared meaning (Burleson, 2009). These activities are message production, message interpretation, and interaction coordination. They are affected by the channels used and by interference/noise.

communication process
a complex set of three different and interrelated activities intended to result in shared meaning

Message Production

Message production is what we do when we *encode* a message. We begin by forming goals based on our understanding of the situation and our values, ethics, and needs. Based on these goals, we recall an effective canned plan script and adapt it to the current situation.

message production
what we do when we encode a message

Message Interpretation

Message interpretation is what we do when we *decode* a message. We read or listen to someone's words, observe their nonverbal behavior, and take note of other visuals. Then we interpret the message based on the canned plan scripts we remember that seem similar. Based on this interpretation, we prepare a feedback message.

message interpretation
what we do when we decode a message

Interaction Coordination

Interaction coordination consists of the behavioral adjustments each participant makes in an attempt to create shared meaning (Burgoon, 1998) (Photo 1.4). Shared meaning occurs when the receiver's interpretation is similar to what the speaker intended. We can usually gauge the extent to which shared meaning is achieved by the sender's response to the feedback message. For example, Sarah says to Nick, "I dropped my phone and it broke." Nick replies, "Cool, now you can get a Droid™." To which Sarah responds, "No, you don't understand, I can't afford to buy a new phone." Sarah's response to Nick's feedback message lets Nick know he misunderstood her. The extent to which we achieve shared meaning can be affected by the channels we use and by the interference/noise that compete with our messages.

interaction coordination
the actions each participant takes to adjust their behavior to that of their partner

channel
the route traveled by the message and the means of transportation

Photo 1.4 In what ways have you engaged in interaction coordination with an advisor, instructor, or supervisor?



Hero Images/Getty Images

Channels

Channels are both the route traveled by the message and the means of transportation. Face-to-face communication has three basic channels: verbal symbols,

emoticons

textual images that symbolize the sender's mood, emotion, or facial expressions

acronyms

abbreviations that stand in for common phrases

media richness

how much and what kinds of information can be transmitted via a particular channel

synchronicity

the extent to which a channel allows for immediate feedback

interference/noise

any stimulus that interferes with the process of achieving shared meaning

physical noise

any external sight or sound that distracts us from the message

psychological noise

thoughts and feelings that compete with the sender's message for our attention

APPLY IT

What symbols do you use to express emotions virtually for anger? Frustration? Laughter? Excitement? Pride? Why?

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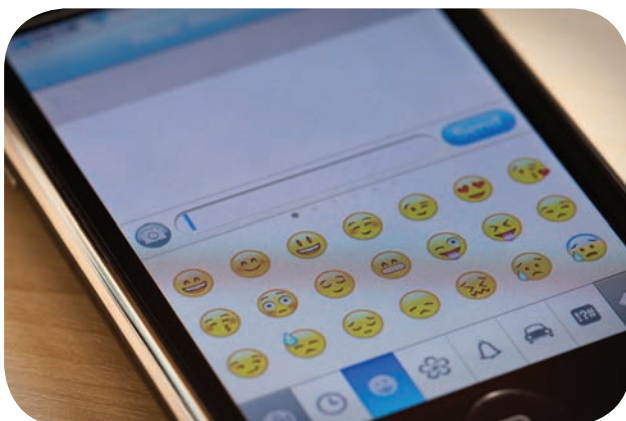
nonverbal cues, and visual images. Technologically mediated communication uses these same channels, though nonverbal cues such as movements, touch, and gestures are represented by visual symbols like **emoticons** (textual images that symbolize the sender's mood, emotion, or facial expressions) and **acronyms** (abbreviations that stand in for common phrases) (Photo 1.5). For example, in a face-to-face interaction, Barry might express his frustration about a poor grade verbally by noting why he thought the grade was unfair, visually by showing the assignment along with the grading criteria for it, and nonverbally by raising his voice and shaking his fist. In an online interaction, however, he might need to insert a frowning-face emoticon (☹) or the acronym "POed" to represent those emotions and nonverbal behaviors.

With so many technology-driven channels available for communicating today, we must now thoughtfully select the best channel for our purpose, audience, and situation. We can do so by considering media richness and synchronicity.

Media richness refers to how much and what kinds of information can be transmitted via a particular channel. Face-to-face is the richest channel because we can hear the verbal message content and observe the nonverbal cues to interpret its meaning. Sometimes, however, communicating face-to-face is either impossible or not a good use of time. The less information offered via a given channel, the leaner it is. The leaner the channel, the greater the chances are for misunderstanding. For example, texts and "tweets" are lean because they use as few characters as possible whereas videoconferencing channels such as Skype and FaceTime are richer because we can observe nonverbal cues almost as much as in a face-to-face setting.

Synchronicity is the extent to which a channel allows for immediate feedback. Synchronous channels allow communication to occur in "real time" and asynchronous channels allow for "lag time." Synchronous channels allow for immediate feedback to clarify potential misunderstandings whereas asynchronous channels provide time to careful craft and revise our messages (Condon & Cech, 2010). Generally, you should use a rich channel if your message is complicated, difficult, or controversial. It is also usually a good idea to use a synchronous channel in these cases. You might choose an asynchronous channel, however, if you could benefit from having extra time to carefully organize and word your message. On the other hand, use a lean channel when you merely want to convey simple and emotionally neutral information. Figure 1.1 illustrates the continuum of communication channels available today.

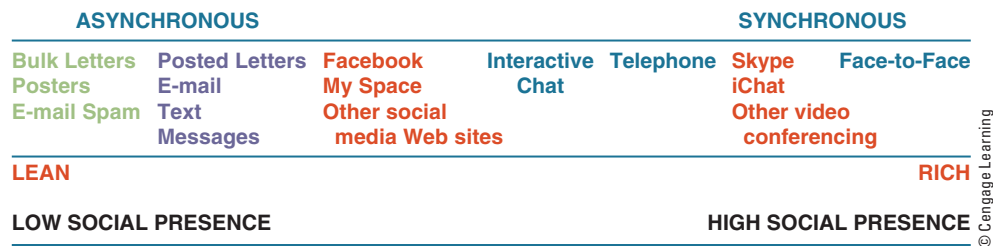
Photo 1.5 What emoticons and acronyms do you use in text messages and why?



Thomas Weightman / Alamy

Interference/Noise

Interference, also referred to as **noise**, is any stimulus that interferes with the process of achieving shared meaning. Noise can be physical or psychological. **Physical noise** is any external sight or sound that distracts us from the message. For example, when someone enters the room, a cell phone goes off, or someone near us is texting while a speaker is talking, we might be distracted from the message. Or, when communicating online, we might be distracted when we get a Facebook or Twitter notification. **Psychological noise** refers to the thoughts and feelings we experience that compete with the sender's message for our attention. So when we daydream about what we have to do at work or feel offended when a

**Figure 1.1**

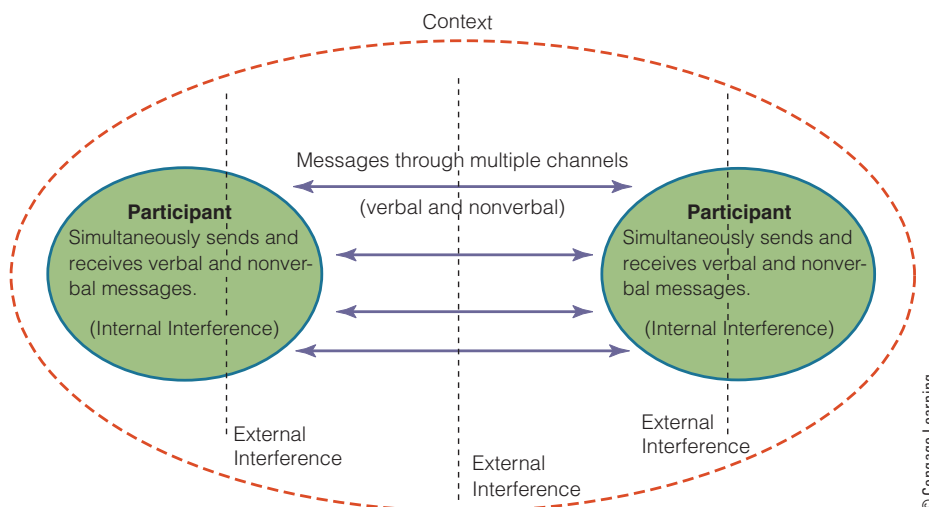
Continuum of communication channels

speaker uses foul language, we are being distracted by psychological noise. Recall how Jennifer in the opening vignette was distracted by both physical and psychological noise while attempting to multitask getting herself ready for work. That's why it is a good practice to close social media sites and power off smart phones while engaged in important face-to-face or online conferences, meetings, or classroom discussions.

A Model of the Communication Process

In summary, let's look at a graphic model of a message exchange between two people presented in Figure 1.2. The process begins when one person who we will call Andy is motivated to share his thoughts with another person, Taylor. Andy reviews the communication situation, including the communication context, and sorts through the scripts in his canned plan library to find one he thinks will be appropriate. Based on this script, he encodes a customized message and shares it with Taylor.

Taylor decodes the message using her understanding of the situation and matching it to scripts in her canned plan library. She might misinterpret Andy's intended meaning because she is distracted by physical or psychological interference/noise, or because her scripts don't match Andy's. Taylor encodes a feedback message using a script from her canned plan library as a guide. She then shares her feedback message and Andy decodes it. If Taylor understood what Andy was saying, he will extend the conversation. If, on the other hand, Andy believes Taylor misunderstood his meaning, he will try to clarify what he meant before extending the conversation. Finally, the communication process is not linear. In other words, both Andy and Taylor simultaneously encode and decode verbal and nonverbal messages throughout the message exchange.

**Figure 1.2**

Model of communication

Characteristics of Communication

Just as we learn to walk, so do we learn to communicate. Because communication is learned, we can always improve our ability to communicate. Several communication characteristics provide a foundation for practicing and improving our communication skills.

Communication Has Purpose

Whenever we communicate, we have a purpose for doing so. The purpose may be serious or trivial, and we may or may not be aware of it at the time. Here we list five basic purposes we'll be addressing throughout the book.

1. **We communicate to develop and maintain our sense of self.** Through our interactions, we learn who we are and what we are good at.
2. **We communicate to meet our social needs.** Just as we need food, water, and shelter, so too do we need contact with other people. Two people may converse happily for hours about inconsequential matters that neither one remembers later. Still, their communication functions to meet this important human need.
3. **We communicate to develop and maintain relationships.** For example, when Beth calls Leah to ask whether she'd like to join her for lunch to discuss a class project, her purpose actually may be to resolve a recent misunderstanding, because she wants to maintain a positive relationship with Leah.
4. **We communicate to exchange information.** Whether trying to decide how warmly to dress or whom to vote for in the next election, we all communicate to exchange information. We do so through observation, reading, and direct communication with others both face-to-face and virtually.
5. **We communicate to influence others.** We may communicate to try to convince friends to go to a particular restaurant or to see a certain movie, a supervisor to alter the work schedule, or an instructor to change a grade.

Communication Is Continuous

We are always sending and interpreting messages. Even silence communicates if another person infers meaning from it. Why? Because our nonverbal behavior represents reactions to our environment and to the people around us. If we are cold, we might shiver; if we are hot or nervous, we might perspire; if we are bored, happy, or confused, our nonverbal language will probably show it.

Communication Is Irreversible

Once an exchange takes place, we can never go back in time and erase the communication. We might be able to repair damage we have done, but the message has been communicated. When you participate in an online discussion or leave a post on a blog, you are leaving an electronic "footprint" that others can follow and read. E-mails, IMs, and text messages are not always completely private either. Once you push the "send" button, not only can't you take it back, but you have little control over who the receiver might forward it to or how it might be used publicly. That's why Sarah decided not to post a picture of herself with her friends at the local pub on her Facebook page.

Even though she could limit which of her “friends” could see it, she also knew that any of them could also then share it with others, as well. She didn’t want a photo like this to hurt her professional image.

Communication Is Situated

Communication occurs within a specific setting that affects how the messages are produced, interpreted, and coordinated (Burlinson, 2009). Do you swear when you talk? For most of us the answer to that is “it depends.” While we may occasionally use curse words when we are with friends or peers, many of us wouldn’t consider swearing in front of our supervisors, teachers, grandmothers, or religious leaders. Similarly, the interpretation of the statement “I love you” varies depending on the setting. During a candlelit anniversary dinner, it may be interpreted as a statement of romantic feelings. If a mother says it as she greets her daughter, it may be interpreted as motherly love. If it is made in response to a joke delivered by someone in a group of friends gathered to watch a football game, it may be interpreted as a complement for being clever.



Photo 1.6 How might you signal trust and intimacy during a conversation?

Communication Is Indexical

How we communicate is also an **index** or measure of the emotional temperature of our relationship at the time. For instance, when they are getting in the car to leave for a holiday, Laura says to Darryl, “I remembered to bring the map.” She is not just reporting information. Through her tone of voice and other nonverbal cues, she is also communicating something about the relationship, such as, “You can always depend on me,” or “You never remember to think of these things.” More specifically, communication may signal the level of trust; who has control; and the degree of intimacy in a relationship (Millar & Rogers, 1987).

Trust is the extent to which partners believe they can rely on, depend on, and have faith in their partners (Photo 1.6). For instance, Mark says, “I’ll do the final edits and turn in the paper.” Sandy replies, “Never mind, I’ll do it so that it won’t be late,” which may signal that she doesn’t trust Mark to get the group’s paper in on time.

Control is the extent to which partners believe themselves to be “in charge” in the relationship. When Tom says to Sue, “I know you’re concerned about the budget, but I’ll see to it that we have enough money to cover everything,” through his words, tone of voice, and nonverbal behavior, he is signaling that he is “in charge” of the finances. In turn, Sue may respond by either verbally responding or nonverbally showing she agrees with him or by challenging him and asserting her desire to control the budget. In other words, control is communicated with either complementary or symmetrical feedback.

Complementary feedback signals agreement about who is in control, whereas **symmetrical feedback** signals disagreement. If Sue says, “Great, I’m glad you’re looking after it,” her feedback complements his message. But if Sue responds, “Wait a minute, you’re

index

measure of the emotional temperature of our relationship at the time

trust

the extent to which partners have faith that their partners will not intentionally do anything to harm them

control

the degree to which one participant is perceived to be more dominant or powerful

complementary feedback

a message that signals agreement about who is in control

symmetrical feedback

a message that signals disagreement about who is in control

intimacy

the degree of emotional closeness, in a relationship

spontaneous expressions

spoken without much conscious thought

constructed messages

formed carefully and thoughtfully when our known scripts are inadequate for the situation

culture

a system of shared beliefs, values, symbols, and behaviors

ethics

a set of moral principles held by a society, group, or individual

the one who overdrew our checking account last month,” she is challenging his control with a symmetrical response. Relational control is not negotiated in a single exchange, but through many message exchanges over time. The point, however, is that control is negotiated through communication.

Intimacy is the degree of emotional closeness in a relationship. When Cody asks Madison what she is thinking about, and Madison begins to pour out her problems, she is revealing a high level of intimacy in the relationship. If she replies, “Oh I’m not really thinking about anything important. Did you hear the news this morning about . . .,” her subject change may signal that the relationship is not intimate enough to share her problems.

Communication Messages Vary in Conscious Thought

Recall that creating shared meaning involves encoding and decoding verbal messages, nonverbal cues, and even visual images. Our messages may (1) occur spontaneously, (2) be based on a “script,” or (3) be carefully constructed.

Many messages are **spontaneous expressions**, spoken without much conscious thought. For example, when you burn your finger, you may blurt out, “Ouch!” When something goes right, you may break into a broad smile. Some messages are *scripted* and drawn from our canned plan libraries. Finally, some are **constructed messages** that are formed carefully and thoughtfully when our known scripts are inadequate for the situation.

Communication Is Guided by Cultural Norms

Culture may be defined as a system of shared beliefs, values, symbols, and behaviors. How messages are formed and interpreted depends on the cultural background of the participants. We need to be mindful of our communication behavior as we interact with others whose cultural backgrounds differ from our own, so we don’t unintentionally communicate in ways that are culturally inappropriate or insensitive.

According to Samovar, Porter, and McDaniel (2007) “a number of cultural components are particularly relevant to effective communication. These include (1) perception, (2) patterns of cognition, (3) verbal behaviors, (4) nonverbal behaviors, and (5) the influence of context” (p. 13). Because cultural concerns permeate all of communication, each chapter of this book points out when certain concepts and skills may be viewed differently by members of various cultural groups. The authors of the *Diverse Voices* feature found in many chapters in this text explain how they or their culture views a concept presented in the text.

Communication Ethics

Ethics are moral principles held by a society, group, or individual that differentiate right from wrong. In other words, ethics reflect what we believe we “ought to” and “ought not to” think and do. Every field of study—from psychology and biology to sociology and history—has a set of ethical principles designed to guide the practice of that field. Communication is no exception. Every time we communicate, we make choices with ethical implications. The general principles that guide ethical communication include:

1. **Ethical communicators are honest.** “An honest person is widely regarded as a moral person, and honesty is a central concept to ethics as the foundation for a moral life” (Terkel & Duval, 1999, p. 122). In other words, we should not intentionally try to deceive others.

2. **Ethical communicators act with integrity.** In other words, ethical communicators “practice what they preach.” The person who says, “Do what I say, not what I do,” lacks integrity. We often refer to such individuals as hypocrites. The person who “practices what he or she preaches” acts with integrity.
3. **Ethical communicators behave fairly.** A fair person attempts to be impartial. To be fair to someone is to gather all of the relevant facts, consider only circumstances relevant to the situation at hand, and not be swayed by prejudice. For example, if two siblings are fighting, their mother exercises fairness if she allows both children to explain “their side” before she decides what to do.
4. **Ethical communicators demonstrate respect.** Behaving respectfully means showing regard for others, including their point of view, their rights, and their feelings, even when they differ from ours.
5. **Ethical communicators are responsible.** Responsible communicators recognize the power of words. Our messages can hurt others and their reputations. So we act responsibly when we refrain from gossiping, spreading rumors, bullying, and so forth.

Bright Side and Dark Side Messages

Interpersonal communication scholars, Spitzberg and Cupach (2011) came up with metaphors to characterize the differences between ethical/appropriate and unethical/inappropriate communication. They label messages that are both ethical and appropriate as **bright side messages**. In contrast, **dark side messages** are unethical and/or inappropriate. “Hard dark side” messages are somewhat ethical and unethical because they are honest, but also potentially damaging to the relationship. “Easy dark side” messages are somewhat ethical and unethical because they are dishonest in order to maintain a good relationship. Finally, “evil dark side” messages are both disrespectful and damaging to the relationship (see Figure 1.3).

Let’s use Liz as an example. She just spent a fortune having her hair cut and colored and asks her good friend, Pat, “Do you like my new hairstyle?” Pat, who doesn’t really like the new look, could respond to Liz as follows:

Bright side response: “Liz, it doesn’t matter what I think. I can see that you really like how it looks and that makes me happy.” (This response is ethical and appropriate. It is both honest and respectful.)

Hard dark side response: “Wow Liz, it’s a dramatic change. I liked your hair long and I’d always admired the red highlights you had. But I’m sure it will grow on me.” (This response is honest but could hurt Liz’s feelings and damage the relationship.)

Easy dark side response: “It looks great.” (This response is dishonest but doesn’t hurt Liz’s feelings.)

Evil dark side response: “It doesn’t matter what you do to your hair, you’re still fat and ugly.” (This response is unethical and inappropriate. It is hurtful and damaging to Liz’s feelings and the relationship.)

As you can see, relationships may benefit from bright, hard, and easy side responses depending on the situation. But dark side responses damage people and relationships.

bright side messages
both ethical and appropriate

dark side messages
not ethical and/or appropriate

	Ethical		
Appropriate	Bright Side	Hard Side	Inappropriate
	Easy Side	Evil Dark Side	
	Unethical		

Figure 1.3

Understanding dark-side messages

We often face ethical dilemmas and must sort out what is more or less right or wrong. In making these decisions, we reveal our ethical communication standards. Each chapter in this book features “A Question of Ethics” case related to material in that chapter. Consider each case and the questions we pose based on these ethical communication principles.

Communication Competence

communication competence

the impression that communicative behavior is both appropriate and effective in a given situation

Communication competence is the impression that communicative behavior is appropriate and effective in a given situation (Spitzberg, 2000, p. 375). Communication is *effective* when it achieves its goals and *appropriate* when it conforms to what is expected in a situation. Our goal is to communicate in ways that increase the likelihood that others will judge us as competent.

Communication competence is achieved through personal motivation, knowledge acquisition, and skills practice (Spitzberg, 2000, p. 377). First, we have to be *motivated*—that is, we must want to improve. Second, we must know what to do. Third, to improve, we must practice communication skills we learn.

Credibility and social ease also influence whether others perceive us to be competent communicators. **Credibility** is a perception of a speaker’s knowledge, trustworthiness, and warmth. Listeners are more likely to be attentive to and influenced by speakers they perceive as credible. **Social ease** means managing communication apprehension so we do not appear nervous or anxious. Communicators that appear apprehensive are not likely to be regarded as competent, despite their motivation or knowledge.

credibility

a perception of a speaker’s knowledge, trustworthiness, and warmth

social ease

communicating without appearing to be anxious or nervous

Communication Apprehension

Communication apprehension is “the fear or anxiety associated with real or anticipated communication with others” (McCroskey, 1977, p. 78). Although most people think of public speaking anxiety when they hear the term *communication apprehension* (CA), there are actually four different types of CA (Photo 1.7). People who experience *traitlike communication apprehension* feel anxious in most speaking situations. About 20 percent of all people experience traitlike CA (Richmond & McCroskey, 2000). People who experience *audience-based communication apprehension* feel anxious about speaking only with a certain person or group of people. *Situational communication apprehension* is a short-lived feeling

communication

apprehension

fear or anxiety associated with real or anticipated communication with others

Photo 1.7 Does public speaking make you nervous? If so, you are like 75% of the population. Did you know that speaking effectively requires some nervousness?



Dennis MacDonald / PhotoEdit

of anxiety that occurs during a specific encounter, for example, during a job interview. Finally, *context-based communication apprehension* is anxiety only in a particular situation, for example, when speaking to a large group of people. All these forms of communication anxiety can be managed effectively in ways that help convey social ease. Throughout this book, we offer strategies for managing communication apprehension in various settings.

The combination of motivation, knowledge, skills, perceived credibility, and social ease make up competent communication. The goal of this book is to help you become a competent communicator in interpersonal, group, and public speaking situations.



COMMUNICATE ON YOUR FEET

Speech Assignment

Introduce a Classmate

The Assignment

Following your instructor's directions, partner with someone in the class. Spend some time getting to know him or her and then prepare a short 2-minute speech introducing your partner to the rest of the class.

Questions to Ask

1. What is your background? (Where were you born and raised? What is the makeup of your family? What else do you want to share about your personal background?)
2. What are you majoring in and why?
3. What are some of your personal and professional goals after college?
4. What are two personal goals you have for this class and why?
5. What is something unique about you that most people probably don't know?

Speeches of Introduction

A speech of introduction is given to acquaint a group with someone they have not met. We make short "speeches" of introduction all the time. When a friend from high school comes to visit for a weekend, you may introduce her to your friends. Not only will you tell them her name, but you will probably mention other things about her that will make it easy for your friends to talk with her. Likewise, a store manager may call the sales associates together in order to introduce a new employee. The manager might mention the new team member's previous experience, interests, and expertise that will encourage the others to respect, help, and become acquainted with the new employee.

Speeches of introduction also often precede formal addresses. The goal of the introducer is to establish the credibility of the main speaker by sharing the speaker's education, background, and expertise related to the topic and to build audience interest.

Speech to Introduce a Classmate

Because your classmate will not be giving a formal address after you introduce him or her, we suggest you organize your speech as follows:

1. **The introduction:** Start with an attention catcher—a statement, story, or question tied to something about the speaker that will pique audience curiosity. Then offer a thesis and preview of main points, which can be as simple as "I'm here today to introduce [name of person] to you by sharing something about his personal background, personal and professional goals, and something unique about him."
2. **The body:** Group the information you plan to share under two to four main points. For example, your first main point might be "personal background," your second main point "personal and professional goals," and your third main point "something unique." Then offer two or three examples or stories to illustrate what you learned regarding each main point. Create a transition statement to lead from the first main point to the second main point, as well as from the second main point to the third main point. These statements should remind listeners of the main point you are concluding and introduce the upcoming main point. For example, "Now that you know a little bit about [name of person]'s personal background, let's talk about his personal and professional goals."
3. **The conclusion:** Remind listeners of the name of the classmate you introduced and the two to four main points you discussed about him or her. Then, end with a clincher—a short sentence that wraps the speech up by referring to something you said in the speech (usually in the introduction) that will encourage listeners to want to know him or her better.

WHAT WOULD YOU DO?

A Question of Ethics

Molly has just been accepted to Stanford Law School and calls her friend Terri to tell her the good news.

MOLLY: Hi Terri! Guess what? I just got accepted to Stanford Law!

TERRI: *[Surprised and disappointed]*: Oh, cool.

MOLLY: *[Sarcastic]*: Thanks—you sound so enthusiastic!

TERRI: Oh, I am. Listen, I have to go—I'm late for class.

MOLLY: Oh, OK. See you.

The women hang up, and Terri immediately calls her friend Monica.

TERRI: Monica, it's Terri.

MONICA: Hey, Terri. What's up?

TERRI: I just got some terrible news—Molly got into Stanford!

MONICA: So, what's wrong with that? I think it's great. Aren't you happy for her?

TERRI: No, not at all. I didn't get in, and I have better grades and a higher LSAT score.

MONICA: Maybe Molly had a better application.

TERRI: Or maybe it was what was on her application.

MONICA: What do you mean?

TERRI: You know what I mean. Molly's black.

MONICA: Yes, and . . . ?

TERRI: Don't you see? It's called affirmative action.

MONICA: Terri, give it a rest!

TERRI: Oh, please. You know it and I know it. She only got in because of her race and because she's poor. Her GPA is low and so is her LSAT score.

MONICA: Did you ever stop to think that maybe she wrote an outstanding essay? Or that they thought the time she spent volunteering in that free legal clinic in her neighborhood was good background?

TERRI: Yes, but we've both read some of her papers, and we know she can't write. Listen, Monica, if you're black, Asian, American Indian, Latino, or any other minority and poor, you've got it made. You can be as stupid as Jessica Simpson and get into any law school you want. It's just not fair at all.

MONICA *[Angrily]*: No, you know what isn't fair? I'm sitting here listening to my so-called friend insult my intelligence and my ethnic background. How dare you tell me that the only reason I'll ever get into a good medical school is because I'm Latino. Listen, honey, I'll get into medical school just the same way that Molly got into law school—because of my brains, my accomplishments, and my ethical standards. And based on this conversation, it's clear that Molly and I are way ahead of you.

Describe how well each of these women followed the ethical standards for communication discussed in this chapter.

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Communication Improvement Plans

You can use a personal communication improvement plan to hone your skills and become a more competent communicator. As you read each chapter, select one or two skills to work on. Then write down your plan in four steps.

1. **Identify the problem:** "Even though some of the members of my class project group have not produced the work they promised, I haven't spoken up because I'm not very good at describing my feelings."

2. **State the specific goal:** “To describe my disappointment to other group members about their failure to meet deadlines.” Hint: Be sure to identify a measurable outcome.
3. **Outline a specific procedure for reaching the goal:** “I will practice the steps of describing feelings. (1) I will identify the specific feeling I am experiencing. (2) I will encode the emotion I am feeling accurately. (3) I will include what has triggered the feeling. (4) I will own the feeling as mine. (5) I will then put that procedure into operation when I am talking with my group members.”
4. **Devise a method for measuring progress:** “I will have made progress each time I describe my feelings to my group members about missed deadlines.”

Figure 1.4 provides another example of a communication improvement plan, this one relating to a public speaking problem.

Problem: When I speak in class or in the student senate, I often find myself burying my head in my notes or looking at the ceiling or walls.

Goal: To look at people more directly when I’m giving a speech.

Procedure: I will take the time to practice oral presentations aloud in my room. (1) I will stand up just as I do in class. (2) I will pretend various objects in the room are people, and I will consciously attempt to look at those objects as I am talking. (3) When giving a speech, I will try to be aware of when I am looking at my audience and when I am not.

Test for Achieving Goal: I will have achieved this goal when I am maintaining eye contact with my audience most of the time.

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Figure 1.4

Sample communication improvement plan

Reflection and Assessment

At its core, communication is the process of creating shared meaning whether in informal conversations, group interactions, or public speeches via flat print, face-to-face, or technology-enhanced channels. To assess how well you’ve learned what we addressed in these pages, answer the following questions. If you have trouble answering any of them, go back and review that material. Once you can answer each question accurately, you are ready to move ahead to read the next chapter.

1. What is the nature of communication and the role of canned plans and scripts in it?
2. Describe the process of communication and how interference may impact it.
3. What are the key characteristics of communication?
4. What does it mean to be an ethical communicator as related to bright side and dark side messages?
5. What is a competent communicator and what steps can you take to improve your communication competence?



COMMUNICATE!

MindTap®

RESOURCE AND ASSESSMENT CENTER

Now that you have read Chapter 1, go to your MindTap for *Communicate!* for quick access to the electronic resources that accompany this text.

Applying What You've Learned

Impromptu Speech Activity

Identify one of your “heroes.” Your hero may or may not be famous. Identify one of the five ethical principles of communication this hero’s life adheres to and why. In your two to three minute impromptu speech, provide at least two incidents that serve as evidence regarding how this person demonstrates/demonstrated the principle.

Assessment Activities

1. Visit your Facebook page. If you don’t have an account, you might make one to observe while completing this course or ask a friend if you can look at theirs. Find one example of ethical communication, and describe the principles of ethical communication that it follows.
2. Find an example of unethical communication on Facebook and describe the principles that it doesn’t follow.

Skill-Building Activities

1. **Identifying Elements of the Communication Process** For the following interaction, identify the message, channels, contexts, interference (noise), and feedback:

Maria and Damien are meandering through the park, talking and drinking bottled water. Damien finishes his bottle, replaces the lid, and tosses the bottle into the bushes at the side of the path. Maria, who has been listening to Damien talk, comes to a stop, stares at Damien, and says, “I can’t believe what you just did!” Damien blushes, averts his gaze, and mumbles, “Sorry, I’ll get it—I just wasn’t thinking.” As the tension drains from Maria’s face, she smiles and says, “Well, just see that it doesn’t happen again.”

1. Message
2. Channels

3. Contexts
 - a. Physical
 - b. Social
 - c. Historical
 - d. Psychological
4. Interference (noise)
5. Feedback

Complete this activity, and see the author's answers on MindTap for *Communicate!*.

2. Communicating Over the Internet Consider the advantages and disadvantages of communicating via the following Internet-based mediums: e-mail, newsgroups, Blogs, iChat, Facebook, Twitter, and Skype. Enter your thoughts into a two-column table, with advantages in the first column and disadvantages in the second. Did your analysis produce any discoveries that surprised you?

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